MINUTES OF THE CLARE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS

Approved 1/15/2025

225 W. Main St.
Harrison, Michigan 48625

Unapproved minutes
December 18, 2024

Meeting was called to order at 9:01 a.m.

Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America

District 2 Dale Majewski, District 4 Jeff Haskell, District 5 David Hoefling, District 6 Jack Kleinhardt, District 7 Gabe Ambrozaitis, District 8 George Gilmore and District 9 Rick Fancon

COMMISSIONERS ABSENT

District 1 Marlene Housler and District 3 Samantha Pitchford

OTHERS PRESENT

Clerk & Register of Deeds Lori Mott, Administrator Lori Phelps and members of the public

APPROVAL OF AGENDA

It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Gilmore to approve the agenda, **motion carried**.

APPROVAL OF MINUTES

It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the minutes of the Committee of the Whole Meeting on November 6, 2024 and the Board of Commissioners Meeting of November 13, 2024, **motion carried**.

GENERAL PUBLIC COMMENT

Citizens expressed concern regarding gas-like odors, black substances covering their plants, apparent spills of black substance in the roadway in their neighborhood, passed around photographs of each and asked for the Board of Commissioners for help in getting other government agencies to respond to their continued complaints.

COMMUNICATIONS LIST

1. City of Harrison Master Plan update – No discussion

ADMINISTRATOR'S REPORT

Administrator Lori Phelps provided the Commissioners with updates regarding items being looked at by the legislators, changes that are needed to county policies, the county audit, grants she is perusing, Michigan Municipal Risk Management Authority (MMRMA) insurance renewal, the wage study she is working on (she will have a summary for each employee), alternate funding for trial courts study currently ongoing and the Standard & Poor's (S&P) credit rating interview for the Road Commission Bond request. Administrator Phelps informed the Board Members that they would be voting on a resolution for the Road Commission Bond at the January 15, 2025 meeting.

HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES

1. Veterans Affairs
   It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve the Michigan Veterans Affairs Agency Grant in the amount of $76,647.55, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Hoefling, Ambrozaitis, Gilmore, Fancon, Kleinhardt, Majewski and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Pitchford
   Motion carried

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION

1. Statutory Finance Committee
   It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve Statutory Finance Committee meeting minutes of November 12, 2024 in the amount of $137,798.39 and the minutes of November 25, 2024 in the amount of $94,401.72, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Majewski, Hoefling, Fancon, Ambrozaitis, Gilmore, Kleinhardt, and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Pitchford
   Motion carried

2. Monthly Expenditures
   It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the expenditures for the month of November, 2024 in the amount of $3,211,208.28 with the General Fund expenditures totaling $1,143,612.20, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Hoefling, Gilmore, Fancon, Kleinhardt, Majewski and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Pitchford
   Motion carried

3. Budget Adjustments
   It was moved by Commissioner Gilmore, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve budget adjustments #25-12 in the amount of $66,508.39, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Gilmore, Hoefling, Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Kleinhardt, Majewski and Haskell
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Pitchford
   Motion carried

4. Board of Commissioners Meeting Dates

   a. It was moved by Commissioner Kleinhardt, seconded by Commissioner Fancon to approve the Board of Commissioners meeting dates through December 2025 with dates consistent with the third Wednesday of the month unless specified on the posting with meeting to begin at 9:00 a.m., **motion carried**.

   b. It was moved by Commissioner Fancon, seconded by Commissioner Gilmore to approve the Finance meeting dates as presented through December 2025 starting at 9:00 a.m. with dates consistent with the off week of payroll, **motion carried**.

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION - continued

4. Statutory Finance Committee

    c. It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to approve the Committee of the Whole meeting dates through December 2025 with dates consistent with the first Wednesday of the month with meetings to begin at 9:00 a.m., **motion carried**.

5. Holidays
   It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the holiday schedule as presented for calendar year 2025, **motion carried**.

6. Wage Discussion
    a. It was moved by Commissioner Kleinhardt, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to increase the salaries of both the Clare County Clerk and Treasurer to $75,000.00 per year as recommended by the Wage Committee, Administrator Phelps confirmed she looked at every county in the state and compared the population, taxable value and millage rates, which narrowed it down to 14 counties. Out of those 14 counties she then compared the wages, benefit packages, duties and office size to come up with the average wages. In addition Commissioner Haskell added and Administrator Phelps confirmed that the Clerk and Treasurer made the same wage in all the comparable counties, roll call vote revealed:

       Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Kleinhardt, Hoefling, Ambrozaitis, Gilmore, Fancon, Kleinhardt, Majewski and Haskell
       Nays: (0)
       Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Pitchford
       Motion carried

    b. It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Gilmore to follow the recommendations of the Elect Prosecutor Andrew Santini to support his staffing and budgeting process, Chairman Haskell confirmed that Prosecutor Elect Santini gave his word and guaranteed he would stay within his budget and increases would come from decreasing personnel employees so he can pay the assistant prosecutors a higher wage, roll call vote revealed:

       Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Majewski, Gilmore, Hoefling, Ambrozaitis, Fancon, Kleinhardt and Haskell
       Nays: (0)
       Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Pitchford
       Motion carried

CLERK/REGISTER OF DEEDS REPORT

Clerk and Register of Deeds Lori Mott introduced a new employee Isha Walter. Clerk and Register of Deeds Mott informed the Board of Commissioners that she has received the reimbursement she requested from the State of Michigan for the Presidential Primary in the amount of $59,000.00 and for the August Primary Election in the amount of $9,000.00, which goes back into the General Fund. Clerk and Register of Deeds Mott also informed the Board of Commissioners that at a recent conference the Bureau of Elections confirmed there is no discussion regarding reimbursing wages for early voting in the future and they do not expect any such reimbursement in the future. She also updated them on legislation that would increase election costs at the county and local level regarding curbside voting and bilingual ballots.

CLERK/REGISTER OF DEEDS REPORT - continued

Clerk and Register of Deeds informed the Board of Commissioners that once the State takes control of the Courts funds all revenue generated to the County would be also controlled by the State.

TREASURER'S REPORT

Nothing to report as Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger was unable to attend the meeting.

CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Chairman Jeff Haskell attended and participated an award ceremony for Michigan Works.

VICE CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Vice Chairman Dale Majewski reported that he has been attending his meetings and talked about House Bill 5428, which will change park recreation pass to an automatic charge on your license plate renewal unless you specifically choose that you don't want to purchase the pass.

COMMISSIONERS' REPORT

Commissioner Hoefling gave a report on each of the township meetings he attended.

Commissioner Ambrozaitis welcomed and introduced the new Hayes Township Supervisor, Brenden Powell.

Commissioner Gilmore had no report.

Commissioner Kleinhardt reported on the vast number of house bills being proposed in Lansing by the State Legislators.

Commissioner Fancon had no report.

STATE OF THE COUNTY BUDGET

Administrator Phelps reported that the unaudited fund balance is $5.8 million and sits at 39% of the full county budget.

PUBLIC COMMENT

A community member expressed his appreciation for the new public address (PA) system that is coming soon, gave comment on how nice the swearing in ceremony for the elected officials was, asked for consideration regarding the upcoming selection of committee members that all three Airport Committee members were pro-airport unlike the current committee. He made comments regarding the requested stipend for the County Clerk and thought there should be a study regarding the difference in cost for the Clerk or Election Source to program the ballots and asked that the Commissioners support the Road Commission Bond request.

A community member asked for help at the South end of Harrison regarding the toxic substance he believes is being dispersed.

Meeting Adjourned at 10:19 a.m.

Lori Mott, Clerk
Clare County Board of Commissioners

Jeff Haskell, Chairman
Clare County Board of Commissioners